PAULODEAEDIT

Travel Radio Australia and we're back in Khan in France at the International Golf Travel Market and I've caught up with Paul O'Day from Golf in Ireland and Ireland Tourism. Welcome to the program Paul. Thanks for having me on, thanks.

Now Paul tell us a bit about what you're doing here at the stand this year. Tourism Ireland has a fantastic presence, there's all sorts of great people who talk about their businesses and products. Yeah, yeah so it's brilliant to be here at the OIGTM.

We have 20 industry on the stand here, so that's caused from Folchard, Tourism Northern Ireland, all the way through to the hotels, courses and the MCs from Ireland. Again, every region here is, every region in Ireland is taken care of, they're all here. Again, they're having some great meetings with some brilliant buyers and again, hopefully it's gonna be really positive for Ireland going forward.

And it's not just a golf show, it's about, it's a big tourism show too, isn't it? Yeah, no, definitely again, there's a lot of golf meetings happening but again, there's leisure meetings as well at the same time. So it's brilliant, like it's just a great opportunity to meet some brilliant buyers and just get a chance to kind of, I suppose, really promote Ireland and everything that we have, be it the courses, the hotels, the hospitality, the warm welcome, it's a bit of everything like so. And how did you get into this role? I suppose you were in tourism before this and what's your background? Yeah, I used to work with a company called Experience Ghetto Games, so we were visitor experience in Dublin Cork, all the way in Belfast, so through that role we used to work with a lot of international visitors and I teach them a bit about our national sports, which I'm very passionate about.

And then from there, I moved into Faltrow Ireland, so I worked on the Dublin team in Faltrow Ireland, which again, is the role very close to my heart because I'm from Dublin, I live in Dublin, like it was a brilliant opportunity to work with the tourism trade there. This role came up about six, seven months ago and here we are, so I talk about golf all day, I work on some incredible partnerships that we have, the Ryder Cup, even the IAGTO partnership, like I'm heading over to elevate next week, so we have some brilliant partnerships, it's a really exciting time for golf in Ireland. Again, next year is going to be crazy, this year we had the Walker Cup, we had like the women's Irish Open, the Irish Open and stuff like that as well, so it's never been more eyes on us and it's a great time to be in a role.

And tell us about some of your favourite spots in Ireland, in Dublin and Cork and those sorts of places and I was very lucky to actually grow up in Dublin, in Cromlin. Yeah, I grew up in Cromlin every summer of my childhood was spending in Cromlin because I have Irish parents and I just got yesterday my Irish passport, so I'm a full Irish citizen now, which is great. Apart from those places, which are absolutely fantastic, tell us about, it's really good to get out and see the real

Ireland, isn't it? Yeah, no, definitely and yeah, my dad's actually from Cromlin as well, so I know everywhere you go in Ireland is different, like it's kind of the different regions that we have in Britain, obviously I'm biased, I love Dublin, I've lived there all my life, but we spend our whole summers down the Southwest in Clare, Kerry, like the quality of the courses down there from Tybeg, The Hinch, Ballybunny in there here with us, we have other courses, I've done a ring, collections and everything like that as well, so like the scenery, the welcome, the people, it's just everywhere's so different but everywhere's the same because everyone's so welcome and everyone's so happy again.

The different regions that we have with the Southeast, you have the likes of Rossellaire, British Bay and Corklow that are open next July, you have of course Northern Ireland, which I know from terms of Northern Ireland is here for as well and you have then the Northwest, which is just Donegal, Sligo, Mayo, the Cliffs of Moher are great but Slibley and Donegal is dramatic as well, so it's kind of, we're obviously biased but as a country Ireland is just... Well, I have beautiful memories of County Wexford because we drive down there and because we take the ferry over from from Hollyhead every summer and I spent the whole, as I say, every summer of my childhood there and Wexford has some of the most beautiful beaches, doesn't it? Yeah, definitely, like I know Rossellaire, Corklow, everything, yeah, it's dramatic, it's beautiful, like if you're looking for a beach holiday Wexford's definitely a good place to go Now speaking of golf, this is a golf event, so it would be amiss of us if we didn't speak about some of the greatest golf courses in the whole world which are in Ireland. Yeah, again we have some of the like iconic bucket list courses in the world, obviously you have Royal County Down, you have Port Rush, you have Ballybunyan, you can now know British Bay is opening again next year, but on top of that we have a lot of what we will call trophy courses of the future, like as in there's some courses that haven't been discovered yet but in the international market that are absolutely incredible, be it up in Donegal, with the likes of Rossellene, Port Saland, Ballyliffen, Be it Down, I even like the likes of Killeen Castles here beside me, like an absolutely incredible course, Jermold and Emma works there, so we've Parkland, we've Lynx, we have it all, and we had a company here last year who ran the coach tours around and we interviewed them and it's a really good way, because Ireland is such a compact country, it's so easy to get around on a coach or even a self-drive or even a camper van, it's fantastic. Definitely, you can get from one side of the country to the other in six or seven hours, again we obviously were Ireland's famous for the wide Atlantic way, you can start, I think it's about two and a half thousand kilometers coastline, like you can start off on the top, make your way down to the bottom and make your way to the top, and just the villages, the towns, everyone's so welcome, and no matter what way you do it, we would always recommend to come to Ireland and extend your stay and just actually get a chance to properly meet the local people and get a chance to actually explore the culture, because yeah, you go home happy.

And three experiences that you've done in the past 12 months that sort of really took your breath away. Are we talking about golf here? Just generally golf, whatever, yeah. I kind of recommend

experience Gator Games anyway, because I did work there, I used to work with a lot of even Australian visitors, American visitors, they've never heard about our national sports, and next thing they come over and some of them are just, it's like their life has been changed with the fact that they've heard about this amateur sport, that's just basically like a religion over in Ireland.

Outside, so many I suppose, but speaking of just briefly, briefly on football, our Australian rules football is based on Gaelic football, and we've had many many people coming over players who've actually become professional players in the AFL. Even in the recent times we've had, I know Fimbara Rorty and stuff like that are heading over from Senegal, I think he's moving to Collingwood maybe. I know we have Ushin Mullen that plays with, is he G Long? I can't remember what team he plays with.

I know we have McKenna as well from Toronto, so yeah, like some of the best players Australia's ever had in the AFL have come from Ireland as well. I know Jim Steins is obviously famous over in Australia, so yeah, those games are very similar, they overlap. Again, we obviously had the international rules, I'm not sure when the last time it was played, it was probably five or six years ago, but yeah, two brilliant sports, and I know Australians are very passionate about over there, we're very passionate about Gaelic games over here, and they definitely interlink.

And give me one must-do experience when people are coming to Ireland in your opinion. Can I give you a hundred? That's right, just want to be okay. One must-do, I've already managed to experience the other games, so I will go with Epic.

Epic in Dublin's brilliant experience, this kind of talks about Irish immigration and how people who have emigrated from Ireland have had such an impact on the world as well, so I'll give Epic a shout out here, but they're both Dublin experiences, so. All this can be found on your website and give us the website? The website is Ireland.com as well, so yeah, and again, no matter where you are in the country, there's so many brilliant experiences where there's, yeah, it's hard to get it all into one experience because there's just such an array of things to do and say. Paul O'Day from Ireland.com and Golfin Ireland, thank you so much for being part of the programme, it's been fascinating hearing about the real Ireland and we encourage everyone to head over soon.

Perfect, thanks for having me, yeah, absolutely, make sure you come over and come over soon.